WATERLOO ROCKETRY

Next-Gen Ground Support Software System (Orion)

Preliminary Design Review

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Agenda

01 Overview, Motivation & Feasibility

02 Requirements

03 Explanation of Key Technological Choices

04 Data Modeling

05 Deployment Architecture

06 Testing

07 Project Management

08 Action Items

SECTION 01

Overview, Motivation & Feasibility

01

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Overview

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Motivation

- Source-level breaking changes currently propagate across the stack, often requiring coordinated changes to dashboards and other consumers.
- Data contracts and system state are spread across multiple components, making behaviour harder to reason about and changes harder to validate.
- Adding new data sources and tooling increases maintenance overhead under the current architecture.
- We want a simpler, more reliable stack with stronger guarantees around shared data structures and interfaces.

Feasibility

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SECTION 02

Requirements

02

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Requirements Overview

The GitHub issues `2026-2027-software-issues#51` contains and is the root parent of issues containing:

- general technical directions
- design (tasks and decisions)
  - specification
  - API Protocol and Data Model
- implementation (requirements and tasks)

Please review its content.

General Requirements

Requirement	Motivation
Omnibus MUST remain production-ready until Orion is fully production-ready and is fully replacing Omnibus.	Allow smooth transition and ensure fallback option exists while issues are ironed out.
Orion SHOULD provide one authoritative API server for telemetry, shared state and command routing.	Provides a stable boundary between sources and consumers, and avoid system-wide breaks when a source or consumer is updated.
Public interfaces SHOULD be typed, versioned, documented and machine-checked.	Standardized interfaces to ensure safe interaction and validation of data.
Complete and well organized documentation MUST be provided for all public interfaces, including API, data model, and configuration.	Ensure that the system is usable and mainytainable by future developers and users.
The deployment of the system MUST be reproducible.	Ensure that the system can be deployed in a consistent manner.
The system MUST be easy to configure and the configuration methods MUST be documented.	Ensure that the system can be configured by all users. (Abandoning the current Python-script-based configuration system.)

SECTION 03

Explanation of Key Technological Choices

03

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Go Stack

Replacing the current Python stack with a Go stack.

- It is a **typed** language, aligning with our goal of having typed messages schemas and interfaces.
- It compiles to a binary, which
  - is less dependent on the runtime environment,
  - is easier to deploy, and
  - is easier to distribute.

Go Stack - Key Changes

- Central Processing Server: switching from Python to Go
- Sink and Source modules: switching from Python to Go
- Dependency Management: switching from `uv` to Go's own dependency management tool.
- Testing Framework: switching from `pytest` to Go's built-in testing framework.
  - We might consider using other more feature-rich testing frameworks if it's deemed necessary during development.
- Networking: switching from WebSockets to Protobuf messages over gRPC,
  - it allows for typed messages, and
  - it supports both unary (request-response) and streaming operations, which is useful for supporting both command/info routing and telemetry data streaming.

Deployment

We continue to deploy on Raspberry Pi.

- Raspberry Pi OS, Docker, and Ansible are kept as they allow the deployment to be reproducible and can be used to redeploy the system quickly and consistently.
- Docker container may be further simplified compared to the Python stack, as the new stack is less dependent on the runtime environment and has fewer dependencies.
- Deliver a single binary, and use different CLI flags to configure the binary to run as different modules (e.g. server, sink, source, etc.), which is easier to deploy and maintain.

Launch App

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Data Studio

We are building Data Studio as a intended replacement for the current Omnibus “Data Processing” scripts, which are not well maintained and not intuitive to use.

Goal: a graphical app to review logs and export data, without needing to figure out how to use command-line scripts.

- **Import** Omnibus, Orion and other agreed log formats.
  - For Orion, it strictly follows the Orion data model and API.
- **Plot & Select** series and time ranges interactively.
- **Export** the selection as CSV, images, or other formats.

Data Studio - Proposed Stack

We want to use a modern web stack (e.g. React + TypeScript + D3.js) for Data Studio frontend, and use Go for the logic and data processing backend, which stays consistent with the rest of Orion system. `Wails` is the proposed framework for this stack.

- We might consider Vue for the frontend.
- Wails is sort of Electron, but it uses Go as the backend.
  - It is considered usable for the forseeable future and is actively maintained.
  - The newest version (v3.0.0) just released October 26th, 2026.
    The previous version (v2.17.0) was released mid-October 2026.
  - It was actively maintained with regular commits.
  - Unfortunately, it is not as popular and no public record shows that well-known companies or projects are using or backing it.

A dedicated PDR for Data Studio is planned for the near future.

SECTION 04

Data Modeling

04

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SECTION 05

Deployment Architecture

05

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SECTION 06

Testing

06

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SECTION 07

Project Management

07

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Timelines, and Reviews

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SECTION 08

Action Items

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